

CASE STUDY

Turning Daily Walks into Daily Wins

Redesigning Monster Walk's return experience to boost clarity, emotion, and retention.

Client Talofa Games

Role UX Designer & User Testing Lead

Focus Welcome Back screen redesign — daily retention loop

Outcome 100% clarity on rewards/streaks; users described redesign as "fun, supportive, motivating"

Project Snapshot

Monster Walk by Talofa Games motivates players to walk in real life so they can convert steps to in-game stamina to save monsters from the "evil fog." The "Welcome Back" moment — the first screen players see when they return — should be an exciting re-entry into the game. But our review and user testing revealed this critical touchpoint lacked clarity, emotion, and reward energy.

- **Problem:** Monster Walk's "Welcome Back" screen lacked clarity, emotion, and reward energy, undermining retention.
- **My Role:** UX Designer & User Testing Lead — owned user testing design/execution, synthesized insights into product direction, aligned cross-timezone teams and clients.
- **Outcome:** Redesigned flow validated by moderated testing — 100% clarity on rewards/streaks, users described it as "fun, supportive, motivating," design direction reinforced retention goals.

My Role & Contributions

- **Owned** all user testing design, execution, and pivot strategy — ensuring research directly informed product direction.
- **Synthesized findings** into actionable design changes adopted by the client.
- **Facilitated** cross-timezone team alignment and client communications to keep delivery on track.
- **Identified future opportunities** beyond this redesign to inform roadmap discussions.

Business Context

As a free-to-play game, Talofa Games depends on retention to drive ad views and in-app purchases. Our goal was to strengthen the Welcome Back experience — making it clear, rewarding, and emotional — in order to increase day-1+ retention, session frequency & length, and higher stamina spent per day.

Success Metrics:

- Improved day-1+ retention
- Longer average session duration
- Increased player engagement

- Higher stamina gained/spent per day

The Gap in the Player Experience

We reviewed Talofa's prior research and ran our own testing. While the game concept had strong appeal, the execution of the Welcome Back moment was underwhelming and sometimes confusing.

1. Stamina Cap Confusion → Loss of Trust

Players understood step-to-stamina conversion, but many didn't realize stamina is initially capped at 500. Steps beyond the cap disappeared without explanation — leaving players feeling like they were "losing" steps.

2. No Emotional Payoff

The panel felt static and transactional. No animation, haptics, or celebratory effects. "Welcome Back!" text didn't meet WCAG contrast standards. Without personalization or narrative framing, players lacked a sense of belonging. The intended loop (cue → routine → reward) broke down: stamina caps undermined routine; flat payoff undermined reward.

Constraints

- **No social mechanics** — designs had to motivate players solo since social mechanics had not been built yet.
- **Rewards limited to existing in-game resources** — no new items or art.
- **Fully developed design system** — all new flows had to reuse existing patterns and assets.

These limits forced us to focus on emotional payoff, clarity, and sequencing rather than entirely new systems.

Process: Iterative and Adaptive

We worked in short cycles of testing and ideation — learning from each round, refining concepts, and validating again. This allowed us to stay responsive to client feedback, real user insights, and project constraints.

What We Did	Why It Mattered
Competitive review (Zwift, SelfQuest)	Identified strong progress visualization patterns we could adapt
App audit	Flagged clarity and pacing issues in the existing flow
Rapid sketching & ideation	Generated multiple alternatives quickly under time constraints
Unmoderated user tests (Maze)	Surfaced confusion with stamina caps and core game mechanics
Moderated 1:1 interviews	Explored deeper drivers of retention (see Pivot Point)

Pivot Point

After resolving clarity issues around stamina and mechanics, I proposed shifting focus from what confuses players to what motivates them to return. Through moderated 1:1 interviews with both new and experienced players, we uncovered how monster personality, daily streak rewards, milestones, and anticipation could sustain engagement over time.

Key Insights

My ideation focused on how we might motivate players to continue their daily login streak. I created mid-fi designs that emphasized reaching specific milestones — in this case one week straight of logging in.

Monster personality drives emotional connection

Players described their monsters as companions. Personalized greetings and character-specific copy made the return feel meaningful.

Mystery sustains anticipation

Hiding upcoming rewards created a pull to return. Players wanted to know what they'd get next.

Streaks need visible progress

Stamina meter + streak indicator gave players a clear sense of where they stood and what they were working toward.

Celebration pacing matters

The milestone moment needed to feel earned — slowing the animation created emotional resonance rather than feeling like a loading screen.

Final Design for Delight

We kept all designs within the existing Monster Walk design system and in-game assets, but emphasized personalization, monster connection, excitement, and clarity.

Highlights:

- Personalized monster greeting with playful, character-specific copy
- Animated stamina meter + streak indicator for clear progress visualization
- Teasers for upcoming daily rewards to encourage return visits
- Rotating hidden monster welcome back screen to add novelty and surprise on subsequent logins

We iterated on the daily bonus/streak feature with client and player feedback — optimizing over time for monster engagement, milestones, and an element of mystery by hiding upcoming rewards.

Impact & Product Direction

User Testing Results:

- 100% clarity on rewards and streaks (moderated testing).
- Users described the redesign as "fun," "supportive," "motivating."

Product Direction: Validated that personality + streak celebrations boost user retention.

"I do like how you don't know what you're gonna get tomorrow. So, you know, you better come back tomorrow to see."

"I love my little guys — it's nice they acknowledge I'm back on the grind to help them clear the fog — so having the monster there to greet you is really nice."

Testimonial

"Vanessa confidently led both unmoderated and moderated user studies, turned insights into actionable next steps, and iterated effectively based on client and user feedback. She's flexible and adaptable, revisiting ideas when new insights emerge while keeping the team aligned and moving forward."

"Her reliability, proactive problem-solving, and strategic thinking makes her someone the team can always depend on, both as a collaborator and a leader. Anyone would benefit from Vanessa's combination of skill, work ethic, and user-focused mindset. I'm confident she'll continue to grow, contribute at a high level, and excel."

— Jenny Park, Coach